Learning Styles

A closer look at 4 learning styles

Learning styles and preferences take on a variety of forms—and not all people fit neatly into one category.
But generally speaking, these are the most common types of learners:

Visual

Visual learners take in information best through ways that they can see – images (videos, plays), drawings, diagrams, maps, and colors. Drawing pictures to remember vocabulary words or making diagrams to cement math facts are helpful tools for visual learners.

These are the kids who learn well by taking notes, making lists, highlighting key concepts, and sketching out ideas. They need it to be quiet to study and learn. I found it interesting that reading is not a key method of learning for visual learners. Reading happens in the language center of the brain, making it auditory, rather than visual.

Kinesthetic

Kinesthetic learners are your active, hands-on kids. They learn best through movement and activity. These are the kids who learn through doing and tend to be good at sports, dance, and drama.

They will have a hard time sitting still and may fidget while working. They often like to do two things at once, like listening to music while they study. Kinesthetic learners may be able to focus better sitting on a stability ball while they work.

Being active can help their memorization. For example, these kids may do better practicing their spelling words while bouncing on a mini-trampoline, rather than trying to sit still. Sitting still may actually make it harder for them to pay attention.

Auditory

Auditory learners learn though – you guessed it! – sound. These are the kids who do well with lectures and read-alouds. They probably like to talk and listen to music. They're the kids who do well putting facts to music to study for a test and who respond well to oral directions.

Auditory learners may read out loud to themselves when trying to understand something. They tend to be good with words or language and are abstract, conceptual thinkers.

Tactile

Tactile learners are often lumped with kinesthetic learners because they, too, are hands-on. The difference is that tactile learners learn best through exploring with their senses.

Tactile learners are the kids who like to manipulate things – blocks, math manipulatives, models, and puzzle pieces. These kids learn by doing and touching. Good tactile teaching tips include letting a child "write" out their spelling words with their finger on sandpaper or in shaving cream, using beans as counters when practicing math skills, or building salt-dough maps when studying geography.

Click Here for a Learning Style Quiz you can do with your child.

Click Here to learn about teaching styles.